

aura of a weak home minister as usually it is the home minister who is given this honour. "We don't need stronger laws. We need the home minister to take stronger steps," says Sandeep Dikshit, Congress MP from East Delhi.

Apart from the politics of the job, Sonia has a deep debt of gratitude towards Patil that dates back to October 1999 when she entered Parliament for the first time. At that time Patil sat next to her, and schooled her through the finer nuances of parliamentary etiquette. His school teacher like manners and avuncular demeanour shielded her from the critical gaze of the BJP. Since Patil was well versed in key political and legal affairs, he proved to be an effective mentor. Most important, like the low-profile political secretary Ahmad Patel, he has never gone public about his proximity to 10 Janpath. Until now.

His recent claim that "I have the full blessings of my leader" has not gone down well with 10 Janpath. This is the same mistake that another loyalist, former external affairs minister Natwar Singh had made when he was implicated in the oil-for-food scandal. Sonia gave him the cold shoulder the very next time she met him in public. This is one golden rule of the Congress: mention Sonia's name in times of victory. Never in defeat, and certainly never when you are the object of criticism. By associating himself with Sonia he is forcing her to publicly distance herself from him. The first snub was delivered when he was not invited for a meeting at 10 Janpath to discuss the Delhi blasts. Now, with the growing perception that he has come to symbolise the UPA's ineffectiveness in combating terror, it is becoming more difficult for Sonia to justify his stay at North Block.

Yet, he stays. It is not just Patil's loyalty to the Gandhi family that makes it so difficult for her to do the obvious. It is also his discretion. He handles sensitive information relating to domestic politics but has never used this to further his own ambitions. Home Ministry sources say that one of the first things he did when he took over was to peruse all files relating to leader of Opposition L.K. Advani. It is not too difficult to figure out what he did with this information. Moreover as he himself said, "I am not in much demand. I have no group. I am here just because of them (leadership)." The Congressman from Latur doesn't have the political following of, say, a Sharad Pawar, to challenge Sonia's authority.

That is why he feels so much at home at North Block.

by Priya Sahgal

Bangladeshis in India, and also certain Bangladeshi insurgent groups were involved in terrorist incidents in the country.

Even though the Home Ministry claimed that they were taking measures to tackle illegal immigration by fencing the border, floodlighting and laying roads to enable patrolling, they had not been very effective. The Border Security Force (BSF), responsible for guarding the borders with Bangladesh, claimed that the illegal immigration flow continued. BSF Director-General A.K. Mitra said, "Twelve lakh Bangladeshis had entered India between 1972 and 2005 with valid documents, and not returned home. These are only the legal ones who have disappeared in the country. Can you imagine the number, which enter illegally and merge with the local population?"

Mitra admitted to demographic changes in border areas and said mysteriously, "various government agencies are working on it". What he left unsaid was the fact that political leaders like Paswan considered the large number of illegal

"Bangladeshis who are ALREADY in India should be provided citizenship but FURTHER infiltration be checked."

RAM VILAS PASWAN, LEADER, LOK JANSHAKTI PARTY

Bangladeshis a huge vote bank, waiting to be tapped by "secular and non-communal parties".

Then there is the issue of Mohammed Afzal Guru, which the BJP has been playing up repeatedly in its attacks on the Government being soft on terror. It has become more than obvious that the Congress does not want to take a stand on the mercy petition of Parliament attack accused Mohammad Afzal Guru, lest it upset its Muslim vote bank. The Government has been dithering on his clemency petition since January 2007, despite repeated pressure from the Opposition which demands "nothing short" of death penalty for Afzal. His 107-page petition has been technically pending before the President—first A.P.J. Abdul Kalam and now Pratibha Patil—awaiting "advice" from the Home Ministry. The President is bound to act on the "well-considered" view of the Government which comprises opinion of the Law Ministry, state government concerned (Delhi in this case) with the final seal of approval by the Home Ministry, which then will forward it to the Rashtrapati Bhavan.